



◀ SAMSUNG BD-E6500

Price: ₹16,490

Blu-ray players

Quite clearly, Blu-ray players saw a surge in popularity this year. They seem to have become the must-have accessory device for most HDTV buyers. There are multiple reasons for this – 1. The Blu-ray discs themselves have become slightly less expensive, particularly the Bollywood ones. 2. The Blu-ray version of the movies are now usually stocked side-by-side with the DVDs in stores and 3. High definition enthusiasts want the best possible movie experience and build on a collection at home.

However, the single biggest reason is the drop in prices of the Blu-ray players. Now you get a host of them available for prices starting around ₹5,000, albeit without Wi-Fi streaming capabilities and slightly slower disc startup times. But the reduced entry price means more consumers are buying these devices and even HDTV manufacturers are bundling them with their TVs.

We also saw this year that stores are now stocking Blu-ray discs rather more freely, than earlier, with the knowledge that they will be picked up by consumers. The DVD and Blu-ray versions of the movies are now hitting shelves simultaneously, unlike the earlier trend of making you wait for the Blu-ray. Prices have come down a bit as well, but do expect that slide to continue next year as labels find the increasing sales more secure. Bollywood movies, for example, are now in the region of ₹800 as compared to ₹1,000 and limited availability earlier. Most Hollywood films now cost between ₹900 and ₹1,200, compared to upwards of ₹1,500 earlier. Not a huge price change, but enough to bring it on the shopping list of a lot of consumers. The sales of HDTVs means that consumers are willing to pay that little extra to get a better movie-viewing experience.

Zero1 Winner

Samsung BD-E6500

If performance and price is something that you want to optimally balance, the Samsung BD-E6500 is the

Blu-ray player to consider. Straight off, it manages to have a rather interesting design, thanks to the subtle variations in comparison to the plain rectangular block look that most other Blu-ray players turn up with. The UI of the BD-E6500 is by far the most visually appealing and intuitive Blu-ray player among all the ones that we tested and remains very functional as well. The player boots up the third quickest and the disc playback speed is the second quickest. What was super surprising was that it played back almost any video file format we threw at it and rivals the WD Live HD Media player in terms of compatibility. Extremely sharp and life-like pictures and very good upscaling of SD content. The Philips Blu-ray players come close with this capability, but the rest are far behind. The ₹16,490 expense will be totally worth it.

Worthy Mentions

Philips BDP-5200/51

This Blu-ray player impressed us considerably in our comparison test. There is a lower spec cousin as well – the BDP-3200/94 that costs less than ₹9,000 but does not have Wi-Fi on board. The BDP-5200/51 costs around ₹12,000 and comes with Wi-Fi on board along with some pre-loaded applications. The user interface is the simplest to get around, and the remote is very well laid out. Picture quality is satisfactory, with the trademark Philips colour presets available as options. Picture quality is slightly on the softer side, but the positive is that there is no noise or any artifacts during Blu-ray playback or when upscaling HD content.



Philips BDP-5200/51

Price: ₹12,990



Panasonic DMP-BDT220GW

Price: ₹11,990

Panasonic DMP-BDT220GW

Among all the players that we tested, the Panasonic DMP-BDT220GW (and the BD110GW before that) is the only player to offer on-the-fly 2D to 3D conversion. This will be like the cherry on the top of the cake for those who prefer regular doses of 3D movies. The interface is unique and working around it takes a bit of getting used to the “direction to select” method. Panasonic has worked on improving the video codec compatibility over the previous generation versions. Priced just under ₹12,000.